of an infant recently born'. Buddhism had disappeared from India to such an extent that Bernier didn't even recognize them as adherents of a faith with roots in India.

On Ridiculous Errors and Strange Superstitions

'Bernier was very much the educated European of the early Enlightenment,' writes historian William Dalrymple in *City of Djinns*. 'He knew his classics, was a firm believer in Reason, and had no patience with "ridiculous errors and strange superstitions".' Bernier studied physiology and philosophy under the materialist Pierre Gassendi and was a man of the emerging scientific–philosophical thought of Europe. He felt part of a more 'advanced' civilization, both in terms of its scientific knowledge and its social and political thought.

Consequently, in his letters, he is often dismissive of Indians and their beliefs, especially Gentiles (who were more alien to him, whereas he had access to Europe's considerable body of knowledge and attitudes on Muslims). '[The] Gentiles understand nothing of anatomy,' he writes. 'They never open the body either of man or beast, and those in our household always ran away, with amazement and horror, whenever I opened a living goat or sheep for the purpose of explaining to my Agah the circulation of the blood [recently explained by William Harvey].'

In another letter, he tries to show 'that there is no doctrine too strange or too improbable for the soul of man to conceive', citing examples from Gentile India (and a few from France). During a solar eclipse, he watches 'deluded people' plunge themselves in the Yamuna and 'perform their silly tricks until the end of the eclipse'. Then they 'gave alms to the Brahmens, who failed not to be present at this absurd ceremony'. He ridicules the logic behind these acts, which, he is told, derives from the four Vedas.

These books, he writes, also 'enjoin that the people shall be divided, as in fact they are most effectually, into four tribes [that] are not permitted to intermarry, that is to say, a Brahmen is forbidden to marry a Quettery [Kshatriya], and the same injunction holds good in regard to the other tribes'. Another contemporary French traveller, Jean Baptiste Tavernier (1605–89), also writes about India's caste divisions. 'An idolater will not eat bread nor drink water in a house belonging to any one of a different